

# VOYAGES OF EXPLORATION

SETTING SAIL AROUND THE GLOBE IN THE AGE OF DISCOVERY

Christopher Columbus's voyage across the Atlantic in 1492 sparked an unprecedented opening-up of the world—first by the Portuguese and Spanish, then by the Dutch, English, and French. By 1700, European explorers and colonizers had established themselves globally.

European explorers were motivated by glory, Christian zeal, and—above all—gold, spices, and slaves. The goal was the East, source of legendary riches. With overland routes blocked by Muslim states, maritime routes offered the prospect of outflanking them. By 1488, the Portuguese had rounded southern Africa. Ten years later they reached India and, by 1512, the Spice Islands. There, they were later challenged by the Dutch.

The Spanish went west. Theirs was a more dramatic discovery: an unknown world, America. By the 1550s, they had conquered two empires—the Aztecs and the Incas—and created a huge New World empire. By 1522, they had also completed the first circumnavigation of the globe. English and French efforts were directed initially at finding a way around North America. Though futile, this paved the way for two further European empires there.

“I AND MY COMPANIONS SUFFER FROM A **DISEASE** OF THE **HEART** WHICH CAN BE **CURED** ONLY BY **GOLD**. ”

Hernán Cortés, Spanish explorer, on his quest to defeat the Aztecs, 1519



## Major European voyages

This map shows the date and routes taken by the first European voyages of discovery and exploration: the earliest Christopher Columbus in 1492, through to Francis Drake in 1577–80. Ships sailed for months at a time to cross the vast oceans, often with crude systems for navigation.



**1:13**

Survival ratio of Magellan's circumnavigation

Magellan left Spain in September 1519 with 237 men. Just 18 men made it back three years later. Magellan himself was killed in the Philippines, in April 1521.



SHIPS IN 1519

SHIP IN 1522

## Ships commanded by Magellan

Five ships set sail on Magellan's circumnavigation. Two were wrecked, one abandoned, and one deserted. Only Victoria returned.



ESTIMATED NATIVE POPULATION OF CENTRAL AMERICA

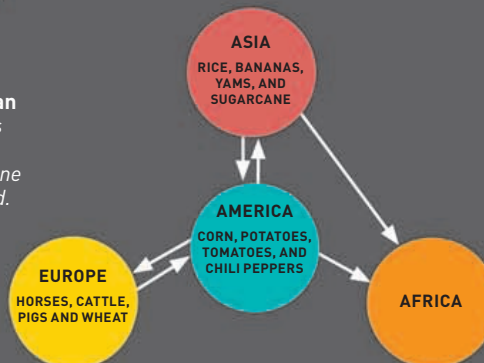


ESTIMATED NATIVE POPULATION OF PERU



## Effect on populations

The Spanish conquests had a devastating impact on native populations. African slaves were taken over to replace them.



## Biological exchange

New foods—and new diseases—passed between Europe and the New World as a direct result of the voyages of discovery. The results were at times beneficial; at others, fatal.

## COST AND IMPACT

European maritime exploration was made possible by better ship types and navigation. But journeys were still arduous, and many ships simply disappeared. The fate of Magellan's fleet in 1519–22 reflected these risks.

Relations with native peoples also proved fraught and almost invariably ended violently. Europeans generally saw natives as a resource to be exploited and Christianized. But the startling death tolls in the New World were more the result of the dislocation of settled ways of life and of imported European diseases than of deliberate policy. The sudden intermingling of previously separate worlds had a dramatic impact in both directions, with crops and animal types introduced to new environments.